count was followed by the US (42.3 crore), Brazil (27.5 crore), Indonesia (19.5 crore), Japan (19 crore), and Mexico (12.6 crore). Of course, these countries had vaccinated a much higher proportion of their populations, but the absolute vaccine numbers in India reflect the nature of the governmental drive.[48] Whether such numbers will be enough and how people, on balance, perceive the government's handling of the pandemic were still open questions at the time of writing. How governmental actions to combat the coronavirus play out on the ground over the next two years will be crucial to the BJP's political fortunes, at least till 2024.

Linked to this is the big challenge of the economy, a crisis that has been greatly aggravated by the pandemic. When *India Today's* 'Mood of the Nation' survey asked Indians what they thought was the single-biggest failure of the Modi government in August 2021, the most common response was price rise/inflation (29 per cent), followed by unemployment (23 per cent), and then the handling of the pandemic (11 per cent).[49] As a die-hard BJP supporter, businessman and regular party fund contributor in Mathura told me, 'The only challenge for BJP is the economy. They don't know what to do. They fail here. Rest all is fine.' The Indian economy was in a crisis even before the national lockdown in March 2020. The BJP may have won the cultural war on Ram but if the economy does not recover, if more jobs are not created, the negative political implications are obvious—'the economy cannot run "Ram Bharose" (up to Ram).'

A recovery is not about higher growth rates alone.[50] This book has shown how the BJP skilfully scaled up social welfare schemes through DBTs and a whole host of schemes after Modi came to power in 2014. He has been a statist; more Left than the Left, as a BJP MP put it.[51] His government wholly embraced the DBT welfare system that was initially tried and piloted under Manmohan Singh. Total DBT payments, in fact, rose twenty-nine-fold (from ₹7,367 crore to ₹2.14 lakh crore) and DBT beneficiaries rose seven-fold (from 10.8 crore to 76.7 crore) between 2013-14 and 2018-19. This has been a central pillar of the Modi era's political economy.[52] Around this welfare system—powered by linked Aadhar cards,